

HORS D'OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

Lessons of Leadership

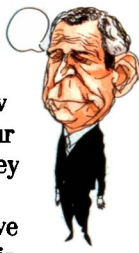


It may be a storm in a ricebowl—but George W has done it again: put his foot where his mouth is. His latest on the cause of the global food crisis being rising affluence and higher food consumption in India may be hard to stomach but it does raise the question of why political leaders never learn that discretion is the better part of valour. There is delicious irony in the fact that his remarks were endorsed by his number two, the aptly named Condoleezza Rice. She too had stated that “apparent improvement” in the diets of people in India and China were among the causes of the current global food crisis. Food for thought but more to do with the frequency of faux pas the higher you go up the ladder. Ask Barak Obama.

Bush, admittedly, is in a class by himself. The most powerful man in the world is also the most accident prone when it comes to tripping up on his tongue. This is the same man who once said: “Oftentimes people ask me, ‘Why is it that you’re so focused on helping the hungry and diseased in strange parts of the world?’” That was just three days after he patted Pope Benedict on the back and said, “Thank you, your Holiness. Awesome speech.” Yet, for some reason, food has been his biggest inspiration: back in January 2000 he told the American people: “I know how hard it is for you to put food on your family”. As he himself summed it up: “They underestimated me”.

He’s not alone. Closer home we have L.K. Advani, possibly our next prime minister, who equated Jinnah with secularism and was punished by his party. What made him make such an amateurish faux pas? I suspect that playing to local galleries tends to obscure the larger implications of the statement. He was in Pakistan and speaking to a local audience but forgetting a truism of 21st century politics: the camera and microphone are always on and in this era of 24 hour “Breaking News”, anything sensational travels faster than the speed of sound. Bush was speaking to Americans but not aware of the controversy it could cause and the speed with which the statistical response proving him wrong would be made public.

Fareed Zakaria, in his latest book *The Post American World*, says that “because the information revolution is so new, we are all just now figuring how to put everything into context”. That includes politicians and leaders. In some cases it may be naiveté and lack of experience, as it was with Rajiv Gandhi and his verbal gaffes, but increasingly it is to do with lack of awareness of how technology and its marriage with media has changed the rules of the game. Anywhere in the world, TV news is now the handmaiden of sensationalism. At Prime Time, politicians are prime targets. something they forget all too often.



SAURABH SINGH



JILTED JEOPARDY:
Lali and Devi

Reverse Exploitation

PATNA Sex can sometimes turn into a politician’s Achilles heel. Except this time it’s a female politician accused of sexual misconduct and the implications go beyond impropriety. When the former body-guard of Bihar Congress MLA Sunita Devi, Bal Yogeshwar Sharma alias Lali, accused her of “sexually” exploiting him for over two years and of threatening to kill him when he “protested”, it caused a flurry in Bihar’s political landscape.

Lali has flaunted two photographs that show him seated intimately with the MLA. He has also released a few letters, purportedly written by Devi, to “prove the relationship”. Lali was posted as Devi’s body-guard from November 2005 to March 2008. However, she claims that she treated Lali as “her brother”. According to the MLA, he had sought Rs 10 lakh from her and created a furore when she refused.

A livid Devi has also described the allegations

as politically motivated. Nevertheless, mounting public criticism and clamour for her resignation did force the beleaguered MLA to quit as president of the state Women’s Cell of the Congress.

The controversy has also claimed Lali’s scalp. The vigilance cell of the state electricity board—where he has been currently posted—has suspended him for approaching the media without registering a formal complaint with his seniors first. But the Patna police are in a quandary as to how to proceed against the ex-MLA since the IPC has no provisions dealing with sexual exploitation of a male by a woman. They have registered a case only under IPC sections that deal with threats.

Meanwhile, the scandal has left the Congress red faced. The AICC has set up an inquiry board committee and has asked Devi for an explanation. Clearly a case of bonhomie gone wrong.

by Amitabh Srivastava